

UNIT 13 AN ENCOUNTER WITH THE COAST GUARD

Trespassing in a Restricted Area

After the incident with the injured motorman and the helicopter rescue operation Captain James leaves the bridge, and goes to his cabin to get some sleep.

Timo Ranta, the Second Mate remains in charge on the navigation bridge. After a few hours the weather conditions start to change and visibility is greatly reduced by fog. Timo gives orders to reduce speed and the Marina proceeds on its route. When the vessel is approaching the area south of Helsinki, the instruments on the bridge start to behave in a strange way.

The automatic steering system, the autopilot, is no longer working properly, and the picture on the radar screen breaks down as well. Timo Ranta, who lacks Captains James' experience at sea, finds himself in trouble. Due to a navigational error on his part the Marina gets off course. Then suddenly there is a complete breakdown, a so-called blackout in the ship's power system and the Marina starts drifting with the strong southerly wind directly towards the restricted area southeast of Helsinki.

Marina's manoeuvre has not gone unnoticed. It is 4 a.m. at Suomenlinna Coast Guard station. Lieutenant Mustasaari is on duty and notices an unknown vessel on the radar screen, heading away from the main fairway towards the restricted area southeast of the station.

Mustasaari decides that he will have to send out a patrol boat to board the foreign vessel and interrogate the Captain.

First he makes contact on the radio. Luckily the radio is now working on board the Marina.

Calling vessel in position

Latitude: 60° 00' North

Longitude: 025° 04' East

Calling vessel in position

Latitude: 60° 00' North

Longitude: 025° 04' East



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This is Finnish Coast Guard, Finnish Coast Guard.
On Channel 16.
Over.

Finnish Coast Guard.
This is Marina.
In position
Latitude: 60° 00' North
Longitude: 025° 04' East

Marina.
Finnish Coast Guard.
Please take channel 10.
Over.

Finnish Coast Guard.
Marina.
On Channel 10.
Over.

Marina.
Finnish Coast Guard.
You are steering a dangerous course. You are heading towards shallow water. You must alter course immediately 180 degrees.
Coast Guard vessel approaching your vessel.
Request permission to come on board.
Over.

Finnish Coast Guard.
Marina.
You are welcome on board.
We are rigging pilot ladder on port side.
Over.

Marina.
Finnish Coast Guard.



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Understood. Pilot ladder is rigged on port side.

Out.

As Lieutenant Mustasaari boards the Marina, he is met by Timo Ranta the Second Mate.

- Good morning. We are from the Finnish Coast Guard. I would like to speak to your Captain immediately.
- Certainly. Come this way, please.

Mustasaari follows Timo Ranta to the navigation bridge, where Captain James is waiting.

- Good morning, I'm Captain James, what can I do for you? What is the reason for your visit?
- Good morning, I'm Lieutenant Petteri Mustasaari from the Finnish Coast Guard vessel. I'm afraid I will have to ask you some questions. Your ship has deviated from the main fairway and you are now in a so-called restricted area.
- Indeed, I had no idea. We had a blackout just now but the power is working again. I realised we were off course. I was relieved that we didn't run aground. What seems to be the problem? This is not a military area, as far as I understand.
- No, it isn't. But in a restricted area foreign vessels can pass only by the main fairway. And it is prohibited to anchor, without a special reason or a permit. May I see your identification papers, please?
- Yes, here you are.
- What is your port of destination?
- It is Kotka.
- What is your port of departure?
- Santander in Spain, with ports of call on route. Our last port was Riga in Latvia.
- And what is the purpose of your visit?
- I am on my way to unload a cargo in the port of Kotka.
- I'm afraid sir I will have to compile an official report on this. You have not been complying with the regulations. You said that you are on your way to Kotka. Why are you not in the main fairway? You are rather far off the route. How do you explain this fact?
- Well, one of our crew members was very badly injured. He was picked up by helicopter in position 59° 40' North and 024° 00' East. After that the weather conditions became worse. There was a breakdown in our power system when the

vessel was passing south of Helsinki Lighthouse. I myself was not on the bridge at the time. Our navigational equipment did not work properly, and there must have been a navigational error of some kind. But then visibility is very bad, there is a thick fog.

- Yes, that's right. Can you show me the logbook? Thank you. Did you send distress signals when your man was injured? Oh, yes here it is. You signalled on channel 16 and the helicopter arrived.
- Yes. It carried our man to hospital for treatment.
- Can I have a look at the Muster Roll, please? Mmm, I can see that one of your crew members is signing off in Kotka. He is of Algerian nationality.
- Yes, he is signing on to a German vessel in Kotka a few days after our arrival.
- I see. Has he got a visa?
- No, he hasn't.
- He needs a transit visa for Finland in this case. You should notify the Frontier Guard authorities on arrival and they may grant him a transit visa.
- All right. I will do that.
- Fine. This completes my interrogation. Would you mind signing this form, please. It will of course have to be passed through the official channels.
- Yes, of course.
- And we will now escort you away from this area back to the fairway. Please follow the Coast Guard vessel.
- All right, yes, that is most welcome. These are dangerous waters.
- Yes, indeed - you were lucky not to run aground or to collide with another vessel. This is an area with great traffic density!
- Well, goodbye, and thank you for your help. Sorry about the inconvenience we have caused.
- No serious harm done. These things happen, Captain. Goodbye, and have a safe voyage!

STUDY THESE SENTENCES

A number of polite phrases were used in the interview. Here are a few excerpts from the dialogues:

Questions /Requests

Would you mind...

I would like to

Polite expressions

Yes, all right.

Yes, of course



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I'm afraid I will have to ...

(used to soften unpleasant
information)

May I please?

Can you show me ... please?

Can I have a look at please?

What seems to be the problem?

What can I do for you?

Sorry about...

Yes, indeed.

Thank you for....

That is most welcome....

Indeed, I had no idea...

Come this way please.

No harm done...



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